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DRAGO

Wale Edun (eh-DOON)

Minister of Finance and Coordinating Minister of the Economy of Nigeria

Addressed as: **Honorable Minister** | Office held since: **June 2023**

Chief Adebayo Olawale "Wale" Edun is committed to implementing bold fiscal policies during the worst cost of living crisis in a generation.

- **Reform Champion**
  Edun is driving Tinubu's reform agenda, floating the currency, removing the oil subsidy, tackling inflation, reducing borrowing, and seeking to increase government revenue.

- **Tinubu's Man**
  Edun has known Tinubu for more than two decades. Their shared history and mutual respect have enhanced Edun's stature and power to shape the country's economic policies.

Edun views himself as a visionary leader, willing to take "actions that were necessary," even if they cause short-term hardships and significant public backlash.

WHY THEY MATTER

Edun is keen to strengthen ties with multinational companies in the banking and financial service sectors, promoting pro-market and foreign currency reforms.

- **Pro-Market Reforms**
  Edun's efforts to stabilize the economy and the country's currency generally align with the interests of foreign companies. He is eager to attract foreign financial expertise and capital as part of his agenda to diversify the economy beyond oil.

- **Extensive Banking Experience**
  Edun is an expert on navigating Nigeria's banking sector, having previously provided advisory services to Nigerian and international investors and served in prominent roles in major Nigerian banks and financial institutions.

While Edun's approach is generally welcoming to foreign banks, he also has stressed the importance of domestic resource mobilization and protecting local market participants.

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MEETING WITH THEM

Edun is a serious interlocutor who almost effortlessly presents facts and figures to defend his policy choices.

- **Relying on Numbers**
  Edun is prone to overwhelm his counterparts with detailed technical explanations, citing the latest statistics on the budget deficit, oil projections, agricultural production, inflation, and foreign direct investment.

- **Seeing the Big Picture**
  When confronted with criticism, Edun is quick to concede the point, but then pivots to the necessity of his reforms. For example, he has stressed that "we were going in a direction that was totally unsustainable."

A businessman who has worked with Edun for about a decade told a journalist that Edun "is somebody that reads people...he knows your strong and weak points."

ON THEIR MIND

- **Naira Rate Rollercoaster**
  After the currency enjoyed a seven-month period of strengthened stability, the naira is at risk of depreciating as foreign investors sell local assets owing to a global risk-off mood caused by escalating trade tensions between the world's two biggest economies and weak dollar supply by the central bank.

- **FATF Grey List**
  The Financial Action Task Force's (FATF), a financial crimes watchdog based in France, in late October removed Nigeria, along with three other African countries after it showed "positive progress" in addressing shortcomings within agreed timeframes.

- **Revised U.S. Visa Policy**
  The United States in August announced that most non-immigrant and non-diplomatic visas issued to citizens of Nigeria will be single-entry visas with a three-month validity period.

- **Increased Political Maneuvering**
  Two years ahead of the next presidential election, Nigerians politicians are already jockeying for positions and alliances. A new opposition group, including two former presidential candidates, plan to challenge Tinubu's reelection efforts.

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NETWORK

Edun's personal and professional experiences are responsible for his deep affinity for the United States and United Kingdom, although he welcomes engagement with China and is sensitive to U.S. political dynamics.

Edun has tried to downplay the effect of a 15 percent tariff on Nigeria, arguing in April that "it's not too bad" in part because oil and minerals are excluded. Edun loudly applauds new ventures whether they be U.S. oil companies or Chinese infrastructure projects.

Edun is one of Tinubu's closest confidants, and he generally works well with the other members of the president's economic team who had served together in Lagos State.

Edun's relationship with Central Bank Governor Yemi Cardoso, for example, reflects a close alignment of experiences and goals. Cardoso, however, has publicly and privately dismissed attempts to pin responsibility for economic hardship on the Central Bank.

CONTROVERSIES

While maintaining a clean personal reputation, Edun faces criticism over the social impact of his economic reforms.

- **High Cost of Living**
  Despite Edun's economic reforms, including an inflation rate rebasing exercise in February 2025, many Nigerians still feel that the cost of living remains high, particularly as food inflation. These economic major concerns led to nationwide protests, known as #Endbadgovernance, in August 2024.

- **Association with Tinubu**
  Tinubu, who is Edun's patron and longtime collaborator, has been dogged by corruption allegations. The president has become deeply unpopular, often a subject of scorn and satire on social media and in public discourse.

Nigerian media sources in mid-October suggested that the Minister was battling a serious ailment, possibly a stroke, requiring his immediate hospitalization in the UK. The Nigerian government denied this rumors, only acknowledging that he had been "indisposed." Edun has since returned to Nigeria, resuming his official duties.

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CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **Minister of Financ & Coordinating Minister of the Economy**, Government of Nigeria (2023 - present)
- **Special Adviser on Monetary Policy**, Government of Nigeria (2023)
- **Chairman**, Denham Management (2008 to 2021)
- **Commissioner for Finance**, Lagos State Government (1999 to 2004)
- **Director**, Stanbic IBTC (1989)
- **Investment Officer**, International Finance Corporation (1986)
- **Head of Treasury**, International Finance Corporation (1980 to 1986)

BIO

Edun grew up in a worldly and privileged home where he developed a passion for philanthropy and boxing. Born in 1956 in Ogun State in southwestern Nigeria, Edun is married to Amy Adwoa Appiah, a daughter of a Ghanaian statesman and British writer. They have three sons, one of which is a British actor.

- **International Experience**
  Edun moved to the UK as a young child where his parents were living, working, and studying. He received a bachelor's degree in economics from the University of London and a master's degree in economics from University of Sussex.

- **Philanthropic Pursuits**
  Edun is involved in youth empowerment initiatives, such as the International Award for Young People Nigeria, which runs the Duke of Edinburgh's award. He is also the Chairman of Livewell Initiative, a health sector NGO, and a Trustee of Sisters Unite for Children.

The Minister is enthusiastic about boxing, having been an amateur boxing champion during his school days. He is the founder and chairman of the Lagos Boxing Hall of Fame and serves as president of Repton, an amateur boxing club in London's East End.